On the battlefield, a battalion would line up with its pikemen in the centre and musketeers on each side. There would be cavalry on their flanks and reserves behind them. Some musketeers might also be formed into mobile companies to give fire support to the cavalry as it advanced. A sergeant with a halberd stood alongside each company organizing its movements and volley fire. A rank of musketeers had to "make ready", "present", and "give fire" as ordered by the sergeant – the whole process taking about 30 seconds with a matchlock musket – and then move out of the way for another rank to fire. When combat was joined at close quarters, the musketeers would use the butts of their weapons as clubs. Infantry could operate offensively, rushing the enemy to engage them in "push of pike", or stand on the defensive. If they were attacked by cavalry, probably the most unnerving experience for foot soldiers, the pikemen would form a bristling square. Since the cavalry had firearms, however, the reach of the 5m (16ft) pike was not necessarily decisive. Cool heads and good discipline were needed to make pike-and-musket infantry effective on the battlefield. Once their formation was broken, the foot soldiers were capable of nothing but a desperate mêlée.

VICTORIOUS ARMY

The creation of the New Model Army gave the Parliamentarian forces a distinct advantage over the Royalists, especially in terms of organization. Between 1645 and 1652 it was repeatedly victorious, subduing Royalists, Scots, and Irish. The civil authorities never liked it, because it was expensive to maintain and became a hotbed of political and religious radicalism. But it was a highly professional army by the standards of its day, led by dedicated, experienced officers, and with a core of veteran soldiers at its heart. It outlived the end of the wars but was eventually disbanded by Charles II at the Restoration in 1660.



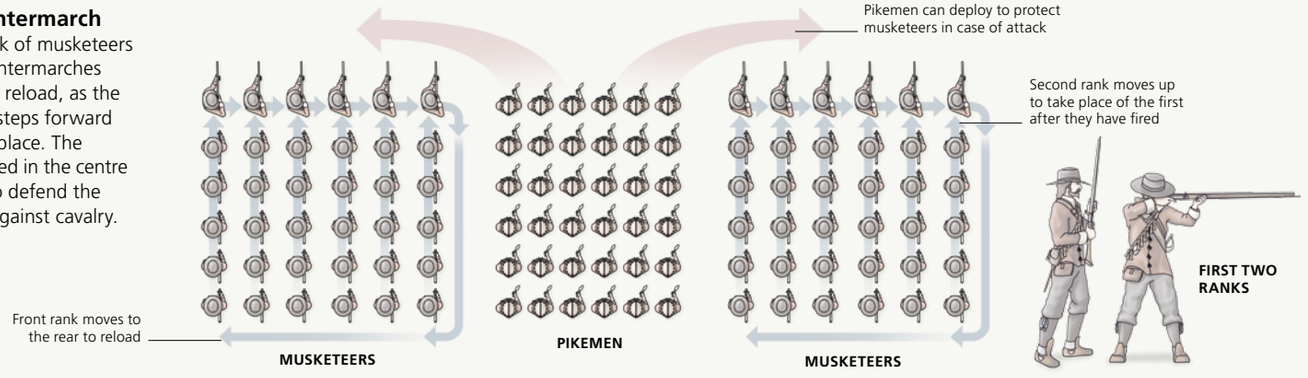
Defending the musketeers
The musketeers were extremely vulnerable to attacks by cavalrymen or pikemen, especially while they were reloading. They were always drawn up on the battlefield accompanied by pikemen, who would come to their aid in the case of attack.

MUSKET AND PIKE TACTICS

In the 17th century European military commanders and theoreticians all agreed on deploying pikemen in close-packed phalanxes and on exploiting matchlock muskets fired in volleys. But differences arose over the numerical balance between pikemen and musketeers, the depth of formation, and the most effective system for firing. Through the first half of the century the proportion of musketeers tended to increase, from equality with the pikemen to double their number. The depth of ranks in the same period lessened, from around ten-deep to six-deep. There were two well known methods for using muskets. The countermarch system associated with Dutch leader Maurice of Nassau aimed to achieve a steady rolling fire. The other method, associated with King Gustav Adolf of Sweden, had three ranks of musketeers firing a simultaneous salvo. This had maximum shock effect, although it left the musketeers entirely dependent upon the pikemen for defence in intervals between volleys while they reloaded. Commanders in the English Civil War employed both systems of firing.

Dutch countermarch

The front rank of musketeers fires and countermarches to the rear to reload, as the second rank steps forward to take their place. The pikemen placed in the centre can deploy to defend the musketeers against cavalry.



Swedish salvee

Three ranks of musketeers – standing, crouching, and kneeling – fire in a single volley. The rear three ranks either move to the front as their colleagues retreat to reload, or line up between them to join in a single salvo of the entire musket force.

